WORLD WAR II

OPERATION EXCESS



Date January 10–11, 1941
Forces British: 1 carrier, 2 battleships, 3 cruisers, 7 destroyers; Axis: 2 destroyers, land-based aircraft
Losses British: 1 cruiser and 1 destroyer; Italians: 1 destroyer
Location Off southern Sicily

The Luftwaffe's Fliegerkorps X moved to bases in Sicily in January 1941. The British mounted a complex convoy operation, Operation Excess, in which merchant ships from Gibraltar were escorted to the south of Sicily by a force, including the carrier *Illustrious*, and passed to cruiser escorts from Alexandria to continue eastward. *Illustrious* was attacked by Stuka dive-bombers on January 10. Hit by eight bombs and partially disabled, she limped to Malta, where air attacks continued. The next day the cruiser *Southampton*, heading for Alexandria, was so damaged by dive-bombing that she had to be scuttled.

THE BATTLE OF CAPE MATAPAN

On March 27, 1941, a substantial force of Italian warships assembled off southern Italy, commanded by Admiral Angelo Iachino on the Littorio-class battleship *Vittorio Veneto*. Iachino had been misled by intelligence reports suggesting the Royal Navy had only one battleship and no aircraft carriers in the sea around Crete. In reality, Admiral Sir Andrew Cunningham had the battleships *Warspite*, *Barham*, and *Valiant*, and the carrier *Formidable*. Once the Italian fleet was at sea, Cunningham set out from Alexandria to intercept, calling on Vice Admiral Henry Pridham-Wippell to join him with a destroyer flotilla and light cruiser squadron from Piraeus.

On March 28 an Italian aircraft spotted Pridham-Wippell's light cruisers and destroyers and Iachino headed to intercept. Shortly after 8:00 a.m. Pridham-Wippell came under fire from Italian heavy cruisers. Iachino executed a pincer movement that threatened to trap Pridham-Wippell's force between the heavy cruisers and *Vittorio Veneto*, but at around 11:00 a.m. torpedo bombers from Andrew Cunningham's carrier *Formidable* arrived on the scene. While the Italian warships were preoccupied with evading air attack, Pridham-Wippell slipped away.



Cape Matapan medallion
Two warships on a parallel course with aircraft overhead adorn this unofficial Italian medal commemorating the defeat at Cape Matapan.

THE ITALIAN RETREAT

Without air cover, Iachino wisely decided to withdraw. Meanwhile Cunningham ordered further air attacks during which *Formidable*'s airmen succeeded in scoring hits on *Vittorio Veneto* and the heavy cruiser *Pola*, slowing down the former and immobilizing the latter. Still unaware that heavier Royal Navy forces were in the vicinity, Iachino ordered Admiral Carlo Cattaneo's heavy cruisers *Fiume* and *Zara* plus three destroyers, to stay behind to rescue *Pola*.

By this time night had fallen. The Italians had no radar and no training in night fighting. Totally undetected by the Italians in the pitch darkness, Cunningham's battleships, which had radar, advanced to around 3,800 yards (3,500 m) of the ships clustered around *Pola* before opening fire. Struck repeatedly by heavy armor-piercing shells from *Valiant* and *Barham's* 15-in guns, *Fiume* and *Zara* were disabled in minutes, on fire, and listing heavily. British destroyers sank two Italian destroyers; only the destroyer *Gioberti* escaped. *Fiume* sank around 11:00 p.m. *Zara* and *Pola* were finished off by torpedoes in the early hours of the following morning.

The battle ended Italian hopes to control the Mediterranean. Mussolini's once proud fleet would not emerge in force again until it surrendered in 1943.



